



This shot took over 100 hours of work to achieve

km stretch, painstakingly identifying the perfect rhinoceros, the perfect spot and the perfect setting for the shot. He got the shot of the rhino charging on day 13 – the camera was sent flying 10 feet, but somehow survived!

Like most professional wildlife photographers, he too is concerned about people crossing that sacred boundary from observer to participant. “If the animal charges at me, and I am the cause, that’s not okay. If an animal charges at something in its natural environment, then, that’s great for me,” says Mukherjee.

Patience and optimism also seem to be ingrained into Mukherjee. He told us about trying to get the perfect shot of the Himalayan brown bear since 2004... He’s made 12 treks already, to different areas, trying to find the elusive bear. He even came across a sloth of five bears once, but wasn’t satisfied with the photographs that resulted. He isn’t disheartened though, and plans to return again soon. “Not getting a photo is very important information, just like in science. It tells us something – maybe the species you’re looking for is not there, or it’s there but is aware of your presence

and is avoiding you, or else you’re not aware of some behavioural pattern of that animal. It’s also a way to improve. For example, when trying to remotely photograph a leopard in a cave I failed. Later I learnt that there was another exit to the cave! You learn from your failures.”

The patience needed seems almost superhuman to us. Whilst talking, he casually mentions that three weeks ago he finally got good shots of the Red Panda... after 10 years of trying!

On a trip to Singalia National Park (North Bengal) in 2007 to try and shoot the pandas, he didn’t see any red pandas, but he did get a glimpse of a Satyr tragopan (a pheasant-like bird). In 2013, when he went back to try and shoot the tragopans, he got the shot in 4 days. However, it wasn’t just 4 days of work, because it was all setup over 40 days in 2007 and 4 days in 2013... his is a continuous journey of experiences.

FOR SCIENCE!

He’s travelled the world too. He’s been to Lake Baikal to photograph the world’s only freshwater seal, and to get his underwater shots he had to cut holes in ice sheets a metre thick on the lake! He’s also been to the Arctic, East Africa, Indonesia, Madagascar, Rwanda, and also hopes to go to Antarctica soon.

His is not just a photography role, and he loves working with researchers and scientists. A recently completed visit to Rajaji National Park was to help scientists from the Wildlife Institute of India figure out a better way to estimate animal populations from the air. His passion isn’t just about documenting nature, but also to do his bit to help conserve it. If his photographs help science in some way, that’s meaningful, but if it can also help create awareness and move some of us to care more about conservation of nature, then that’s just perfect for him.

TECHNOLOGY

Technology has invaded everything, and everyone with a smartphone has essentially become an amateur photographer. It’s also invaded the world of professional photography.

Mukherjee says, “The device isn’t important for me it’s the result that matters. I use drones extensively (currently using a Phantom 4) and have used them in various shoots. I also use two kinds of remotely triggered equipment – infrared cameras where the animal essentially takes its own photo, and a live view camera where I see what is happening in real-time. Technology is just a tool though, and the most important skill is knowing what



You have to be an adventurer to get into this line